suspect because of my background as finance secretary and so lent credence to this criticism.

I was more sensitive to the criticism on the ‘eloquent silence’ of the Reserve Bank. This was by no means deliberate. In normal course, it would take at least a couple of months for the media to take a measure of a new governor, for both sides to get to know each other and for a protocol of communication to get established. The crisis did not allow us the time to go through this familiarization process at the normal pace. In part because of the lack of familiarity, I tended to neglect the communication dimension of my job in those early months.

The criticism was a welcome call for corrective action. My first response was to establish a practice of a media conference following every major crisis-response package by the Reserve Bank.

The first of this series of media conferences was on 28 October 2008, following the first quarterly policy review on my watch. I was not a novice in dealing with the press; I had in the past taken questions from reporters as finance secretary, and also given brief interviews. But facing a media conference as governor was an altogether different proposition since so much seemed to hang on what you said and how you said it. I had gone through answers to possible questions with the staff but I was still nervous. After all, this wasn’t any old time; we were going through a period of acute anxiety and uncertainty, and the media was struggling to interpret my actions and understand my personality. I knew they would be more probing than usual, but would they also be adversarial?

As I entered the conference room with the four deputy governors in tow at 3 p.m., a strange calm suddenly descended upon me. The conference didn’t exactly go as per script; in fact, no media conference does. But I never felt cornered or lost. I believe I gave cogent and reasoned replies to all the questions, including why I had to resort to an unscheduled policy action, that too one as significant as a regime change in monetary policy, just four days ahead of a scheduled policy review. One question that came up several times and in several formulations was whether the government was driving the Reserve Bank’s agenda. Beyond a simple denial, I chose